

Proposal to update the Trial Code of the Most Worshipful Grand Lodge F&AM of Utah

For many years a good amount of the craft has seen the need to update our trial code. This is not just Utah masonry, almost all the Grand Lodges in the Rocky Mountain Conference see the same need. At the 2025 annual communication Most Worshipful Grand Master Joe Milner put together a committee to update our trial code. He assigned to this committee 4 past grand masters who all have had experience interpreting that code and its use. MW Milner and the committee came up with a list of items that needed to be reviewed, updated, and added too.

1. Review the trial code for sections that conflict with our By-Laws and Regulations.
2. Change language that is confusing or misunderstood by those not trained in the legal profession. Examples are Statements, Evidence, and Depositions.
3. Make clear when evidence and statements need to be disclosed to all parties.
4. Change the language and requirements on how to take statements from Masons and non-Masons to fit today's standards.
5. Add options for lodges who may struggle to perform a trial.
6. Clarify the appeals section.
7. Provide boundaries and guidelines regarding a suspension.
8. Provide-directions to Worshipful Masters on how to run a trial, what to instruct the commission, and how to deal with objections.
9. Look at the section requiring a shorthand recorder and modify it to today's expectations
10. Define the ability of Lodges to create forms to fit the circumstance.
11. Explain the difference between a Masonic trial and a civil trial.

Before our first meeting we reached out to several of the Grand Lodges in the Rocky Mountain conference to get copies of their trial code. Several responded and the committee reviewed all of them to see what differed and what was the same. We also had conversations on what was working for them and what was not. After that review the four of us held 7 official meetings throughout the year. At our first meeting we assigned sections for each person to work on and discussed what should be accomplished. For the following four meetings we picked apart the proposals by each member and refined them. What you have presented before you, in our opinion, is the collaboration of many years of experience combined with a deep dive into what every word could mean or be interpreted to mean. During my time as a Mason, I have been a signer on several proposals to modify our code. But in all those proposals I have never been a part of a collaborative effort such as what went into this proposal before you. Thank you for your consideration.

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